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LOCAL PLANNING AREA PARTNERSHIPS

TIPS & TIDBITS

**Analyzing Community Problems -
Designing & Adapting Community Interventions**

Analyzing Community Problems and Solutions

Imagine for a moment that your coalition's mission is to encourage development in a traditionally poor downtown neighborhood. Your first goal is to recruit member, but you find a lack of interest among area residents. So, you work for a month to convince people to join and meet with some modest success. Then, at your first all-coalition meeting, you find that members don't want to work together. The students you have recruited don't trust the police officers who have shown up; the police officers, in turn, pay no attention to the students; and an argument has broken out in one corner of the room between a few fundamentalist Christians and gay right activists. Your head is in your hands. You are halfway through your grant, and it seems that you haven't made any headway whatsoever towards your stated goal. What are you going to do now?

Problems are a fact of life at home, at play and at work. Unfortunately, problems aren't always isolated cases. They tend to be like onions - you peel away one problem only to find another, and then another, and you can't solve the problem you were first interested in until you solve a variety of related problems. For example, you can't increase safety at a crosswalk until you hire more crossing guards. And nobody will apply for the job until you can increase the salary.

In short, we will always be confronted with problems, so the importance of problem solving can't be overstated. That's why this chapter of the Toolbox is focused wholly on the subject. Because most of us labor in groups or coalitions that are working together on an issue, we will focus primarily on the group problem-solving process.

WHAT IS A PROBLEM?

So, what's a problem? How would you define one? We usually define a problem fairly negatively: a problem is a hassle; it's a pain in the neck. This is often true, but more generally, a problem can be considered the difference between what is, and what might be or should be. Believe it or not, problems have their advantages, too. What are some of the good things about problems?

- Most problems are solvable *(or partially solvable, or at least improvable). We can do something about them)*. The task may seem overwhelming *(it surely did when David fought Goliath, or when suffragettes worked to give women the right to vote),* but it's not hopeless. Our optimistic assumption is that we can change the world.

- Problems are opportunities to make some good things happen. If it weren't for problems, what would be our motivation to create change?
- Problems are also challenges. They call upon the best of our abilities and ask us to go beyond what we thought we could do. They make life interesting, and, at least sometimes, fun. Without problems, life could be pretty boring.

You don't agree? Think of all the games based on problem solving. Chess is thousands of years old and is still as popular as ever, based on the number f books you might find on it at your local bookstore. The Rubik's Cube was a national rage some years back. True, the stakes may be very different between a chess game and finding a way to connect with local young people. But both can present a challenge that stretches us in the same ways.

Why is group process particularly important?

Why are we focusing on a collaborative process in this article? Well, for several reasons. You are probably already doing a lot of individual problem solving, and there's a good deal of merit in that. But many of the problems and challenges we face as members of our organizations affect everyone in the group. And, as the saying goes, two heads are better than one - so just imagine what can be accomplished with a room full of dedicated people.

Now, let's change the emphasis for a moment. Why are we focusing on a collaborative process in this chapter. Maybe your group is used to doing things haphazardly on an as-absolutely-necessary basis. Why should you take more time *(already a precious commodity among most groups)* to go through a lengthy process?

- Effective group processes enhance a group's ability to solve problems and make decisions. When working with more than just a couple of people, solving a problem with a set process becomes more manageable.
- It increases the group's efficiency and productivity.
- It increases the group's participation - more people tend to be involved, and, as a result,
- It increases group satisfaction. This means, among other things, that the group is more likely to want to take on other problems. And when they do so, they'll be better placed to solve them.

What is the Problem-Solving Process?

Like any other processes, there are many different tasks that need to be done to properly to solve problems. And again, like any other process, skipping some of the steps will make the job more difficult in the long run.

Here is a brief explanation of each of the steps, to be discussed in more detail in the following sections:

- *Running effective meetings -* Since your work will be in a group, the first thing you need understand is how to hold a good meeting. You may have the problem-solving process down pat, but that won't make any difference if nobody shows up at your meeting, or if no one pays attention to what goes on.
- *Developing facilitation skills* - Strong facilitations skills go hand in hand with running an effective meeting. A good facilitator helps diffuse explosive emotions, makes sure everyone's voice is heard, and steers the group towards the best decisions.
- *Developing recorder skills -* Again, these skills are part of running an effective meeting. A good recorder works hand in hand with the facilitator, and together, they make sure that not only are everyone's opinions heard, but they are also seen, remembered, and followed up on. Having a good recorder is one of the most important parts of setting up an effective meeting.

- *Defining and analyzing the problem* This is the core of the problem-solving process. Sometimes, the real problem isn't originally apparent.
- Generating and choosing solutions.
- *Putting your solution into practice -* If you have followed the process carefully, you'll be surprised at how easy implementing it actually is!

In Summary:

As we have said before, the world is full of problems, and some of them look pretty challenging, to say the least. But the rewards are great. Solutions that are well thought out and carefully implemented ca work. How much can you do?

This article and pictures are provided by "Community Tool Box: Chapter 17. | Section 1.

Contributor: Jenette Nagy, Catie Heaven

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Tool #1: Problem analysis sheet

The following page gives you room to analyze the problem or issue you want your group to address. This information can then be used when you go to step 7 in the "how-to's:"

Set goals and objectives.

Problem Analysis Sheet

What factors put people at risk for (or protect them against) the problem or concern?	
Whose behavior (or lack of behavior) caused the problem?	
Whose behavior (or lack of behavior) maintains the problem?	
For whom is the situation a problem?	
What are the negative consequences for those directly affected?	
What are the negative consequences for the community?	
Who, if anyone, benefits from things being the way they are now?	
How do they benefit?	
Who should share the responsibility for solving the problem?	
What behaviors need to change to consider the problem "solved"?	
What conditions need to change to address the issue or problem?	
How much change is necessary?	
At what level(s) should the problem be addressed?	
Will you be able to make changes at the level(s) identified?	

Tool #2: Components and Elements Background Table

Use this table to look holistically at the intervention you will develop.

	Enhancing Support	Providing Information and Skills Training
Problem/ Issue to be Addressed		
Risk/ Protective Factors		
Targets of Change		
Agents of Change		
Components		
Elements		
Mode/ Context of Delivery		

Tool # 3: Table of Components and Elements

You can fill in this table to look at all of the components and elements that will be done as a part of your intervention. By filling this out, you can see if there are any gaps in your plan that need to be filled in. (For example, if your plan doesn't have any elements related to providing information and skills training, that gap will be very apparent on this table.)

	Providing Information and Skills Training	Enhancing Support and Resources	Modifying Opportunities and Barriers	Monitoring and feedback
Components				
Elements				

Tool # 4: Determining if interventions done by others are appropriate for your purpose and situation

Use this table to help you determine if a particular intervention you know about is right for your purpose and situation.

What is the intervention?	
Is it appropriate for our purpose?	
Is it effective?	
Is it replaceable?	
Is it simple?	
Is it practical?	
Is it compatible to our situation?	